

In this guide we are going to talk about the one document everyone is familiar with... Yes, it is the resume or the C.V. (your curriculum vitae).

Does your resume work? See, the bottom line is that you have to come across as confident, accomplished, qualified, and mature on paper. Of course what you represent about yourself on your resume must also be the truth, that goes without saying but the point I am trying to make is that the resume is one of the main keys that opens the door to getting you in for the interview. Having managed the HR function for a business with hundreds of millions of dollars in revenue, I have read and critiqued my fair share of resumes.

Let me begin by saying that there is no one correct resume format. That said, the format that I will be sharing you today is certainly the one I have found that most interviewers prefer. It is a power format, because it conveys the totality of your professional development in an executive manner.

Resume tips and resources sometimes under estimate the difficulty of skilfully summarizing an entire career on a single page. So let's be clear: crafting a good resume is more than just slapping together a list of the schools you've attended, positions you've held, skills you possess and companies you've worked for. It is one of your most valuable marketing documents in your job search, part of your initial introduction to a company's hiring manager and the go-to reference for your career.

Employers see a lot of resumes when they search for new hires, and it's important to know what they're looking for when you create yours. Presenting your skills and experience in a way that shows how your career aligns with what they're searching for will better ensure that you'll secure an interview.

Want to impress that hiring manager? Whether you're writing a resume from scratch or updating an old one, the following "*do's and don'ts*" are a basic standard that you must comply with.

So the first thing I want to do is to give you a quick list of Do's and Don't's with regard to your resume.

DO's

1. **Customize your resume every time.** Tailor the document for each position you apply for by highlighting your qualifications and expertise that match the specific job requirements. Employers often use screening software that scans documents for particular keywords, so follow the job listing's lead on phrasing.
2. **Develop an easy to pick up pattern of strengths.** May your strengths be on the relationship front or in technology. There is a path that your professional career has followed, and whether you realize it or not, there is a method to the madness. Why one step lead to another must come out as much as possible.
3. **Highlight your achievements.** When listing your past positions, give tangible examples of how the projects you worked on affected the company's bottom line. Did they increase sales, broaden the customer base or reach target markets? Did you receive more responsibility in your company after proving yourself in your current job? This must come across clearly.
4. **Note your accomplishments.** Include a brief list of any special recognition and awards you've received. It's also helpful to note participation in relevant professional organizations and any conferences or workshops you've spoken at.
5. **Proofread and proofread again.** Typos and mistakes tell the hiring manager you are not detail-oriented. You must ensure that your resume is free of such silly errors.
6. **Give a heads up to your references.** If you're going full-steam-ahead on your job search, give your key contacts a heads up that they may be getting calls or emails about you. Send them your most recent resume so they're up-to-date on your current accomplishments and have all the facts in front of them.

7. **Keep it updated.** Even if you're not job-hunting, update your resume every time you accept a new job or complete a significant project. Keeping your job application materials updated regularly will make it seem like less of a burden.

DON'T's

1. **Don't misrepresent your education or job experience.** Even one fabrication can be grounds for termination. Stay honest in all of your job application materials.
2. **Don't give reasons for leaving each job.** Employers often ask about your reasons for leaving your current position at the interview, it is a critical question that reveals information about your character — and you should be ready to talk about why you left — but you don't need to include that information in your resume.
3. **Don't get overtly personal.** Don't put personal information, such as your photo, height, aadhar card number, marital status or religious affiliation, in your resume. You don't want to expose yourself to conscious and unconscious bias on the part of the hiring manager.
4. **Don't state "References available upon request."** Some companies will ask for names up front - follow the instructions in the job posting. But having a separate page with 3 to 5 ready references listed will surely set you apart, of which the more direct bosses you have listed the more impacting this document will be.
5. **Don't worry about using exact dates.** Trying to remember the exact day you started a job 15 years ago is difficult, to say the least. Using the month and year you started and left each position are totally sufficient.
6. **Don't experiment with a crazy format.** Stick to a clean, easy-to-read format. Catch a recruiter's eye with your experience, not with wacky fonts, colors or designs.
7. **Don't use your company phone number or email address.** It's always better to use your personal email address and phone number rather than your professional contact details, even if your current boss is aware of your intent to leave.
8. **Don't include your high school education if you're a college graduate.** But if you're still in college, or a high school diploma is the highest academic qualification you hold, you can include it, else it is looked upon as a space filler.
9. **Don't Include your college GPA / percentage.** The only exception to this is if you're still in college or have just graduated, or if the job posting asks you to include that information.
10. **Don't list past salary information.** Always wait till an offer is made to discuss salary matters. If an application is specifically requesting this information, speak with your advisor how to overcome this limitation.

These are just general guidelines that will assist you in crafting a resume that will come across as a mature document. The hiring manager will see that you know what to put into your resume and what to leave out.

At this point I want to take you over the sections that comprise this power resume format.

1. **OBJECTIVE:** The first section of the power resume is the objective. And this objective is always customized to the job you are applying for. May it be a published position or an unpublished one.

A resume objective is a statement of your goals for employment, usually listed at the top of your resume. A resume objective is typically a brief and powerful statement, that is aspirational in nature.

As I mentioned the most effective objective is one that is tailored to the job you are applying for. It states what kind of career you are seeking, and what skills and experiences you have that make you ideal for that career. An objective must be specific but not so much that it is limiting. The objective must clarify in broad strokes: (a) the position(s) you are seeking, (b) what type of working environment you are looking for, as well as, the (c) advantages you hope to achieve in that role. It may also refer to where you have been and reference past experience.

In the associated template with this video I provide you with several examples of objective statements to get you thinking about the style and content of the objective statement that you create as you get ready to go to market.

2. **SUMMARY OF QUALIFICATIONS:** This is the next major section of a power resume, that is summary of qualifications,

A summary of qualifications lists the highlights of your career up until this point. It is listed next on your resume. Before the employer dives into scrutinizing the specifics of your professional experience, they are presented with this brief paragraph of your professional accomplishments.

The S.O.Q. must demonstrate positive esteem, and factual outcomes. It must end with a statement that markets your S.T.E.E.K.Q. in closing. An effective S.O.Q. is typically a brief paragraph of 5 - 7 sentences. Again, it is wise to customize your S.O.Q. specific to the job you are applying for. It may also be presented in bullet point format.

Before crafting a summary of qualifications, it is helpful to refresh yourself on your select achievements & validation statements, as the goal of an S.O.Q. is to paint a pattern of strengths specific to your domain and/or niche.

And again in the template you will download there are several examples presented of this section, the summary of qualifications. This is for your reference should you want to use a paragraph style or a bullet point style - the point here is to make this impactful without hubris.

3. **PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCES:** We now get to your professional experiences, which is the 3rd section of your resume.

This is the main body of your resume. It lists the companies you have worked for, their location, and the dates you were employed at the firm. It then lists the title(s) you held followed by a brief outline of the role. It may allude to one or two major accomplishments you had while in the position, and should ideally also state who you reported to (position, not name).

The sample template provides you with a formatted example of a finished resume for reference as you think about developing, or updating your own.

4. **EDUCATION, COMPETENCIES, CERTIFICATIONS & AFFILIATIONS:** is the last section of your power resume.

And it lists your educational background, competencies and proficiencies (such as softwares packages, or other certifications such as Six Sigma Blackbelt). It also lists your affiliations and memberships that support your professional story such as the local chamber of commerce, or any such business organizations you maybe a part of. Any general non-degree or non-certification courses you have undertaken are also listed here such as workshops, seminars, or lecture series.

Importantly this section will also include any awards or honors you may have received. Please refer to the example provided to you for further clarification.

IMPORTANT

YOUR RESUME MUST BE ONLY ONE PAGE IN TOTAL, ESPECIALLY AS YOU PROGRESS TO SENIOR ROLES IN YOUR CAREER. EXECUTIVES ARE EXPECTED TO KNOW HOW TO TAKE A 30+ YEAR CAREER AND BE ABLE TO PRESENT IT IN A SINGLE PAGE, SUCCINCTLY WITHOUT MISSING OUT THE ESSENTIAL HIGHLIGHTS.

Now I want you to start making your resume. I want you to study the examples provided in the live session for each section. You need to follow this in the correct flow. Start with your objective, and at the moment it will be a general objective, because you are yet to target specific organizations. If you recall this first section of your resume will be customized to the specific organization and opportunity you shall target.

Next you will create your summary of qualifications, and several examples have been provided for you to capture the highlights of your qualifications and accomplishments across the timeline of your career. You can choose to use a paragraph style format or a bullet point style format - both work equally well.

And then proceed to the section that deals with your professional experience. In this section pay special attention to the sample resume provided. See what sections are provided in bold, see the general formatting of this section, how elements are spaced, and in what order they are displayed. Even more importantly, examine the body of content that makes up the description of each position. Examine how the main accomplishment and the overall scale and size of the responsibilities is captured in this section.

And lastly examine the section that lists your education, your competencies and certifications, as well as, any certifications you may have earned.

At this point do not go over the one page length. The sample resume provided to you is a powerful one with many accomplishments and it is also to demonstrate to you how someone with 20 plus years of experience can include their comprehensive professional story in one single page.